

Four Streets Away

The principle. Gordon services fridges and has never made anything in his life. His mum, Doreen, could not find his house in the dark on Christmas Eve, so he asked Code Overlord to build him something, and it built Follow Doreen: when her car turns into his road, the lights run from the corner to his front door. It worked, so the neighbours wanted the same, so he had Code Overlord wire the whole street into one light show, and when the show got famous, he had it get the crowds there too. By the next Christmas Eve the light show he built for his mum is so famous that she cannot get within four streets of it.

Why it is funny. Every rung is the same thing he built for his mum, done for more people, and every one of them works. The more people it guides to his door, the further away it leaves her, and he is proud of it the whole way.

Every Christmas Eve, Doreen takes a trifle to her son Gordon's. Last year, in the dark, she drove past his house three times and took the trifle home.

"She rang me from Bantock Road. That's not a road that goes anywhere."

Gordon has serviced fridges for thirty years and never made so much as a shelf. In a Co-op car park, with one finger, he typed one sentence into Code Overlord.

"My mum can't find our house in the dark. Build us something so she can."

"What did it build?"

"A line of lights along the kerb. When her phone gets to the corner, they run from there to our front door." A beat. "Like a runway."

"What did you call it?"

"Follow Doreen."

"Why?"

"It's an instruction."

New Year's Day. She turns in at the corner, and the lights run ahead of her to his door. She finds it first time.

"What did she say?"

"Oh, Gordon."

"What did you say?"

"I closed the ticket."

"Then what?"

"Then the neighbours wanted it for their visitors, so I asked Code Overlord to do the whole street."

Nineteen windows open on his laptop at once, one for every house.

"In November the kids on the road asked could all nineteen go at once, to music." A beat. "It seemed a waste not to."

So he asked Code Overlord for a show: nine minutes, every hour from six, always finishing on one line of light from the corner to his door.

Doreen came for her tea on the first night. A lad filmed the whole street running her car in, and put it on the internet. Next night, thirty cars on the verge. By December, coaches.

"They couldn't find us either. So I asked Code Overlord to get them here."

Follow Doreen takes bookings now. Every car gets a slot, and when it turns in at the corner the lights run it to its space, same as Mum.

"And if you've not got a slot?"

"You don't come past the cones. Not for anybody." A beat. "I was very firm with it."

The stewards are the neighbours, in tabards with followdoreen.com across the back. On the M6 there is a brown sign: FOLLOW DOREEN, NEXT LEFT.

"Has your mum seen the sign?"

"She doesn't do motorways."

CHRISTMAS EVE 2027. On the screen in his garage, Follow Doreen counts the crowd in.

"How many tonight?"

"Eighty-one thousand, four hundred and six."

"Who was it built for?"

"Mum."

His phone goes.

"I'm on Bantock Road, duck. I've got the trifle."

"Are you lost, Mum?"

"No, duck. I'm four streets away. I can see it from here."

"Follow the lights, Mum."

"Gordon, everybody's following the lights."

"Have you booked?"

"It's given me the twenty-ninth of December." A beat. "And there's a steward in one of your tabards won't let me past the cones."

"Put him on, Mum."

The steward, down the phone:

"Evening, sir. No slot, nobody comes past the cones. Not for anybody." A beat. "It's your app, sir."

"He's right, Mum. I was very firm with it."

"Could you not have gone and fetched her?"

"The seven o'clock was starting." A beat. "Eighty-one thousand people found us tonight, and Code Overlord's not had one bulb wrong."

Four streets away, Doreen sits in her car on the verge with the trifle on her knee, and over the rooftops one line of light runs from the corner to her son's front door, the way it was built to, for her. Her phone buzzes: Follow Doreen hopes she enjoyed her visit.

"Oh, Gordon."

She gives it five stars.

Card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One plain sentence typed with one finger in a car park, and a terminal starts. When he does the street, nineteen terminals open underneath that one, one a house, at once. The show is a cadence with no end date on it: every hour, every night from six. When the crowds come, the thing he asked it to build for his mum becomes a service strangers book on followdoreen.com, and the count on the garage screen is his own app. Every rung is another sentence to Code Overlord, and each one is the first sentence again, for more people. Follow Doreen is his app: the runway, the street, the show, the bookings and the count. Code Overlord is where he asked for every one of them.

Accent. Nuneaton, north Warwickshire, where Coventry runs into Leicestershire, for the whole cast, the steward included. Carried in the grammar and the word choice, never spelled out: "build us something", "it seemed a waste not to", "there's a steward in one of your tabards won't let me past", "I was very firm with it". "Duck" belongs to Doreen alone. Gordon is the flattest of them, after thirty years of talking to shop managers about compressors; Doreen is the broadest. The date is on screen once, as the caption over the garage: CHRISTMAS EVE 2027.

Three things to decide. The button: keep "Oh, Gordon." and then the five stars, because it is what she said the first time it worked, and giving his app five stars from four streets away is the last laugh and still hers. The brown sign on the M6: keep it, because it is the one picture that shows how far it went without a number. The man off the coach who tells her to shift her car (in the long version, "So have I, duck. I've come for my tea."): leave him out of the cut, because a third voice down the same phone costs a listener more than the laugh gives back.

Condensed from a longer version, which is kept beside this one as the gag bank.